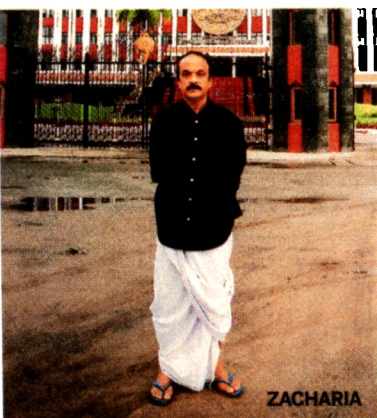


KERALA |

Writer's Block

Writer Paul Zacharia has slammed Kerala's cultural icons—the late writer and cartoonist O.V. Vijayan, veteran poet Akkitham and the late poet Kunjunny—as “dangerously communal”. The reason: they



have accepted awards and honours from Hindutva groups. Two writers don't agree with Zacharia. “Why call a writer communal because he accepted an award from a communal group or said something good about Hinduism?” asks V. Rajakrishnan. Historian M.G.S. Narayanan says, “It's Zacharia's communal mind which makes him say this against three pious persons who have never hurt even an ant.”

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

ISLAMABAD | Taxing Times

Jizya used to be a poll tax early Islamic rulers demanded from non-Muslim subjects. Its 21st century version has driven Sikhs out of their homes in Pakistan's Taliban-dominated areas, particularly Orakzai. Sikh homes have been razed over failure to pay the tax and there have been forced recoveries too, with the Taliban holding Sikh leaders hostage. Most of the displaced Sikhs have taken refuge in Gurdwara Panja Sahib at Hasanabdal, 48 km from Rawalpindi.

In India, Sikhs are incensed and are putting pressure on the Government. “Why can't our Government do anything? Can they do this to US citizens?” says an agitated Kuldeep Singh of Amritsar whose relatives are sheltering at Panja Sahib. The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbhandhak Committee (SGPC) has written to the Pakistan high commission, seeking permission to visit their brethren



SIKHS AT A GURDWARA IN HASANABDAL

in Pakistan. “Hundreds have been rendered homeless and the Government and prime minister are only giving false assurances,” says SGPC chief Avtar Singh. The number of displaced Sikhs, Singh says, is 3,000 and rising by the day.

by Arvind Chhabra

Left Out in the Cold

Two votes the CPI(M) never got were those of Prakash Karat and M.K. Pandhe, both voters in the New Delhi constituency, where the party has never contested. If they went by the party line, would they have voted for the BSP?

LUCKNOW | Copping Trouble



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

The Allahabad High Court has come to the rescue of 18,000 police constables sacked by the Mayawati Government in 2007. The court has slapped a contempt notice on Uttar Pradesh's Director-General

of Police Vikram Singh for failing to implement its earlier order of reinstating all sacked constables. The court has now ordered the state Government to reinstate the cops. The court was responding to a series of petitions by constables who had been sacked on grounds of mass irregularities in their recruitment during Mulayam's regime. Singh had ordered an inquiry into the complaints of scandalous recruitments, following which the constables were dismissed and two dozen officers suspended. The verdict has come as an embarrassment to Mayawati. If she reinstates the constables, her action will provide ammunition to the SP to target her. Uttar Pradesh is going the way of Bihar where the judiciary has to push the executive to work.

by Subhash Mishra